

IGCSE 0990/11 — Paper 1 Reading

Last-Hour Study Sheet • 2 hours • 80 marks • 3 texts in insert

⌚ TIMING PLAN (minutes ≈ marks rule)

Stage	Time	What
0-15	15 min	Read all 3 texts. Underline key ideas + strong language.
15-35	20 min	Q1(a-e) Text A — short answers (15 marks)
35-50	15 min	Q1(f) Text B — summary (15 marks)
50-60	10 min	Q2(a-c) Text C — short answers (10 marks)
60-80	20 min	Q2(d) Text C — language analysis (15 marks)
80-110	30 min	Q3 Text C — extended response (25 marks)
110-120	10 min	PROOFREAD (free SPaG marks)

Q1(a-e) — Text A short answers • 15 marks

- **"Give / Identify"** → lift directly from text.
- **"Explain"** or **"Using your own words"** → translate every word. Lifted = 0.
- A 2-mark phrase explanation (e.g. "adaptable and durable") needs **BOTH STRANDS** covered.
- Mark allocation = number of points. 3-mark Q needs 3 distinct ideas.

Q1(f) — Text B summary • 15 marks (10 Reading + 5 Writing)

- **HARD LIMITS: 120 words. Continuous prose. Own words.**
- Aim for **12-15 dense points**. No intro waffle, no conclusion, no opinion.
- One short overview sentence, then rapid-fire points connected with linking words.
- Lifted phrases score **zero** for that point — translate everything.

Q2(a-c) — Text C short answers • 10 marks

- Same rules. Watch the command word.
- Q2(c) is usually "Explain why..." — needs **inference**, give 3 distinct ideas in own words.

Q2(d) — LANGUAGE ANALYSIS · 15 marks ★ HIGHEST LEVERAGE

Choose 3 words/phrases from EACH of 2 named paragraphs = 6 total. 200–300 words.

The winning 4-step formula per choice:

1. **Quote** word/phrase (1–4 words max, in quote marks)
2. **Literal meaning** (denotation) in context
3. **Connotations / associations** — where else is this word used? what picture?
4. **Effect on reader** — linked to the focus of the question

Killer sentence stems: *"The word X suggests..." · "The connotations of X are..." · "This implies..." · "This creates a sense of..."*

ZERO-MARK PHRASES — never use:

- ✗ "makes us imagine the scene"
- ✗ "the writer cleverly uses..."
- ✗ "paints a vivid picture"
- ✗ "really brings it to life"
- ✗ Just naming a technique ("this is a metaphor") with no effect

Pick words you can SAY SOMETHING ABOUT — not the most "obvious" similes. Include at least one piece of imagery.

Q3 — Extended response on Text C · 25 marks (15 Reading + 10 Writing)

- Format = letter / speech / interview / diary / report — **READ THE PROMPT.**
- **Hit all 3 bullet points** in roughly equal depth (examiners code them A1, A2, A3).
- **Ideas from Text C, in your own words.** Don't just lift — develop, infer, extend.
- **Voice/register MUST match the genre** — interview = conversational; report = formal; speech = direct address.
- Structure: genre-appropriate opening → one section per bullet → brief close.
- 10 writing marks: paragraphing, sentence variety, vocabulary, accurate SPaG.

🎯 SEVEN RULES SPECIFIC TO 0990/11

1. **15 min reading is non-negotiable.** Underline ideas + power words on first pass.
2. **Mark allocation = minutes.** Never blow time on a 2-mark question.
3. **"Own words"** when prompted — translate ruthlessly. Lifted = 0.
4. **Both strands** of any 2-mark phrase (e.g. "X and Y" — explain BOTH).

5. **Q2(d): 6 short quotes, effect > spotting.** Never analyse a whole sentence.
 6. **Q3: all 3 bullets, equal coverage, register matches genre.**
 7. **10-min proofread at end** — homophones (their/there/they're), apostrophes, tenses, capitals, full stops. Free SPaG marks.
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COMMAND WORD QUICK-DECODE

- **Give / Identify** → lift from text
 - **Explain** → infer + own words
 - **Using your own words** → translate or lose marks
 - **Re-read paragraph X** → answer uses ONLY that paragraph
 - **According to the text** → must derive from text, not opinion
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You've got this, Nicole. Stay calm, watch the clock, trust the formula. 💪